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OAKLAND COUNCIL HEARING

ANGRY COMMUNITY DETAILS POLICE RACISM



PASTOR J. ALFRED SMITH (at podium, left) addressing community hearing on police racism at Allen Temple Baptist Church. City Councilman JOSHUA ROSE (far right) with Councilman JOSEPH COTO on his right. Councilman George J. Vukasin not shown.

(Oakland, Calif.) — More than 200 determined and angry East Oakland citizens, overwhelmingly Black, crowded into Allen Temple Baptist Church's community hall last Monday evening to testify before the City Council's special committee investigating police racism.

Committee members councilmen Joshua Rose, Joe Coto and George J. Vukasin heard numerous accounts of police brutality, disrespect, negligence and misconduct recounted by victims as well as witnesses. The most moving and impassioned testimony was that of Mrs. Ernest L. Brown, mother of Ronald Brown, who was shot to death in the back in broad daylight by an Oakland policeman on March 24. (See statement, page 10.)

Citizens began to arrive for the scheduled 7:30 meeting well before the appointed hour. It was well after 11 p.m. when the meeting ended, with many persons still wishing to testify.

Apparently moved by the testimony he had heard, Councilman Rose, chairman of the special committee and of the first community hearing, brought the meeting to a close with the declaration that "the biggest responsibility the committee has is to devise a plan to eliminate racism and racist practices in the Oakland Police Department, because without this we won't have harmony and peace in our community."

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